Machine-Level Programming V: Advanced Topics

CSE 238/2038/2138: Systems Programming

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Slides adapted from Bryant & O'Hallaron's slides

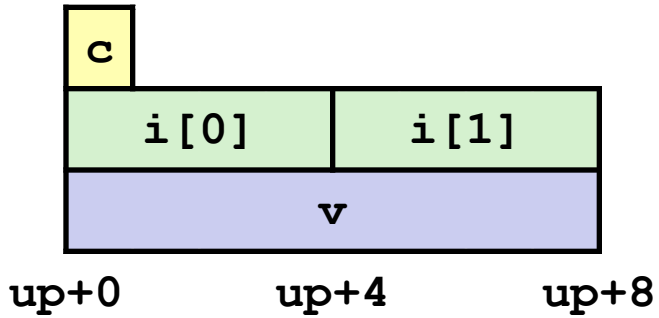
Today

- **Unions**
- **Memory Layout**
- **Buffer Overflow**
  - Vulnerability
  - Protection

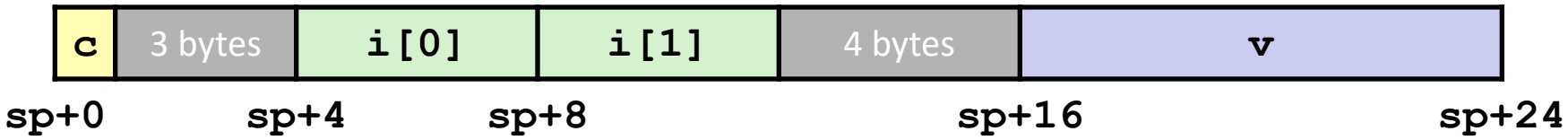
Union Allocation

- Allocate according to largest element
- Can only use one field at a time

```
union U1 {
  char c;
  int i[2];
  double v;
} *up;
```

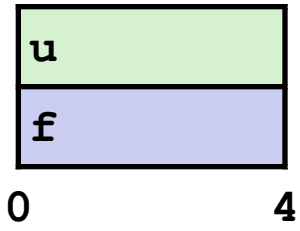



```
struct S1 {
  char c;
  int i[2];
  double v;
} *sp;
```



Using Union to Access Bit Patterns

```
typedef union {
  float f;
  unsigned u;
} unsigned_float_u;
```




```
float bit2float(unsigned u)
{
  unsigned_float_u arg;
  arg.u = u;
  return arg.f;
}
```

Same as `(float) u`?

```
unsigned float2bit(float f)
{
  unsigned_float_u arg;
  arg.f = f;
  return arg.u;
}
```

Same as `(unsigned) f`?

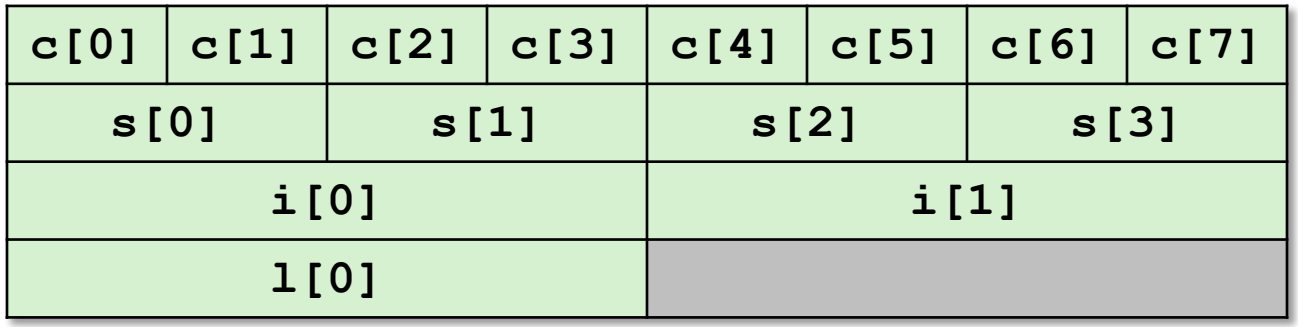
Byte Ordering Revisited

- **Idea**
  - Short/long/quad words stored in memory as 2/4/8 consecutive bytes
  - Which byte is most (least) significant?
  - Can cause problems when exchanging binary data between machines
- **Big Endian**
  - Most significant byte has lowest address
  - Sparc
- **Little Endian**
  - Least significant byte has lowest address
  - Intel x86, ARM Android and IOS
- **Bi Endian**
  - Can be configured either way
  - ARM

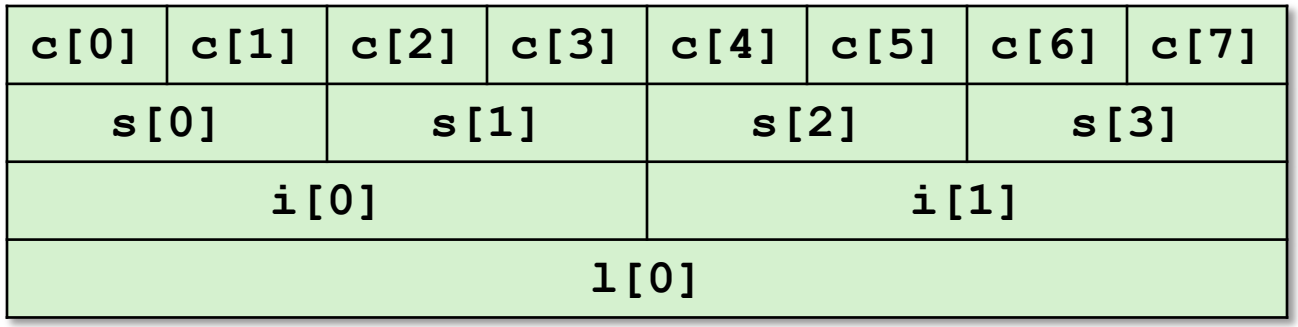
Byte Ordering Example

```
union {
  unsigned char c[8];
  unsigned short s[4];
  unsigned int i[2];
  unsigned long l[1];
} dw;
```

32-bit



64-bit



Byte Ordering Example (Cont).

```
int j;
for (j = 0; j < 8; j++)
    dw.c[j] = 0xf0 + j;

printf("Characters 0-7 ==
[0x%x,0x%x,0x%x,0x%x,0x%x,0x%x,0x%x,0x%x]\n",
    dw.c[0], dw.c[1], dw.c[2], dw.c[3],
    dw.c[4], dw.c[5], dw.c[6], dw.c[7]);

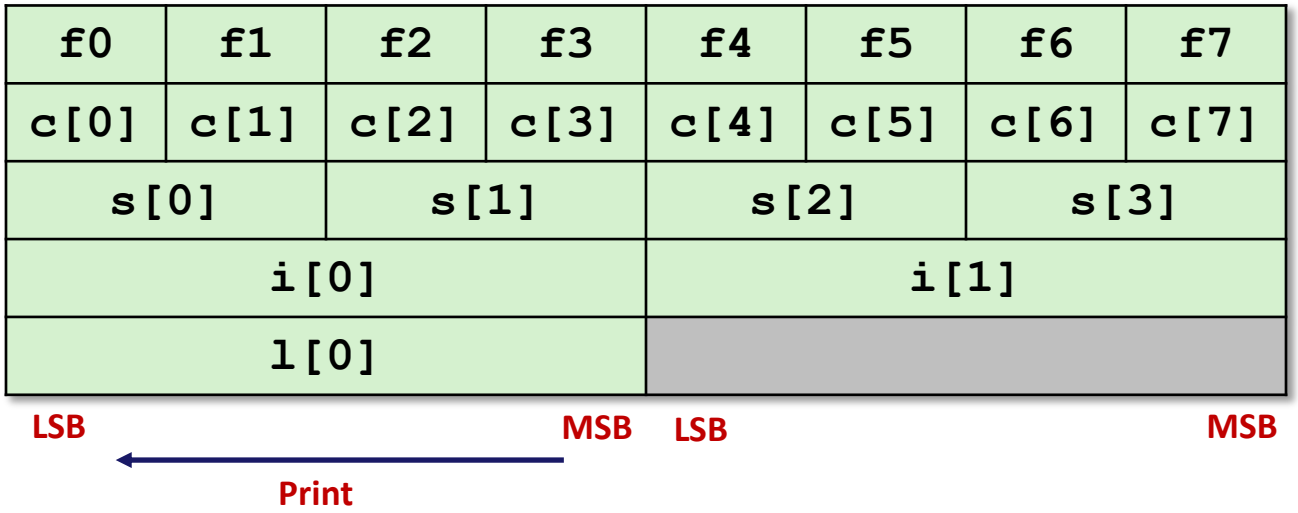
printf("Shorts 0-3 == [0x%x,0x%x,0x%x,0x%x]\n",
    dw.s[0], dw.s[1], dw.s[2], dw.s[3]);

printf("Ints 0-1 == [0x%x,0x%x]\n",
    dw.i[0], dw.i[1]);

printf("Long 0 == [0x%lx]\n",
    dw.l[0]);
```

Byte Ordering on IA32

Little Endian

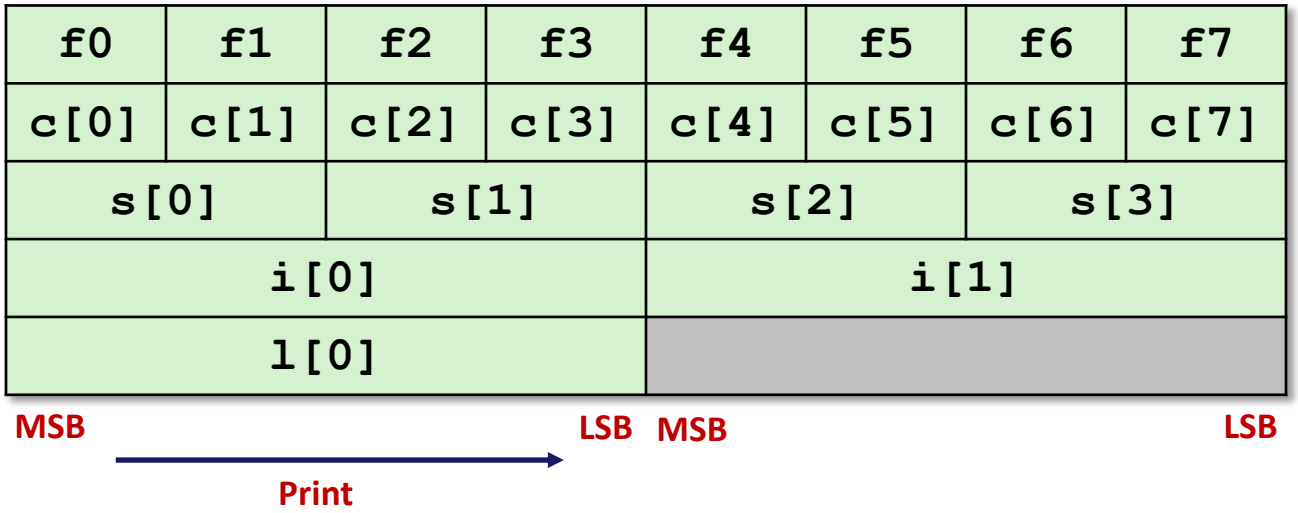


Output:

```
Characters 0-7 == [0xf0,0xf1,0xf2,0xf3,0xf4,0xf5,0xf6,0xf7]
Shorts     0-3 == [0xf1f0,0xf3f2,0xf5f4,0xf7f6]
Ints       0-1 == [0xf3f2f1f0,0xf7f6f5f4]
Long       0   == [0xf3f2f1f0]
```

Byte Ordering on Sun

Big Endian

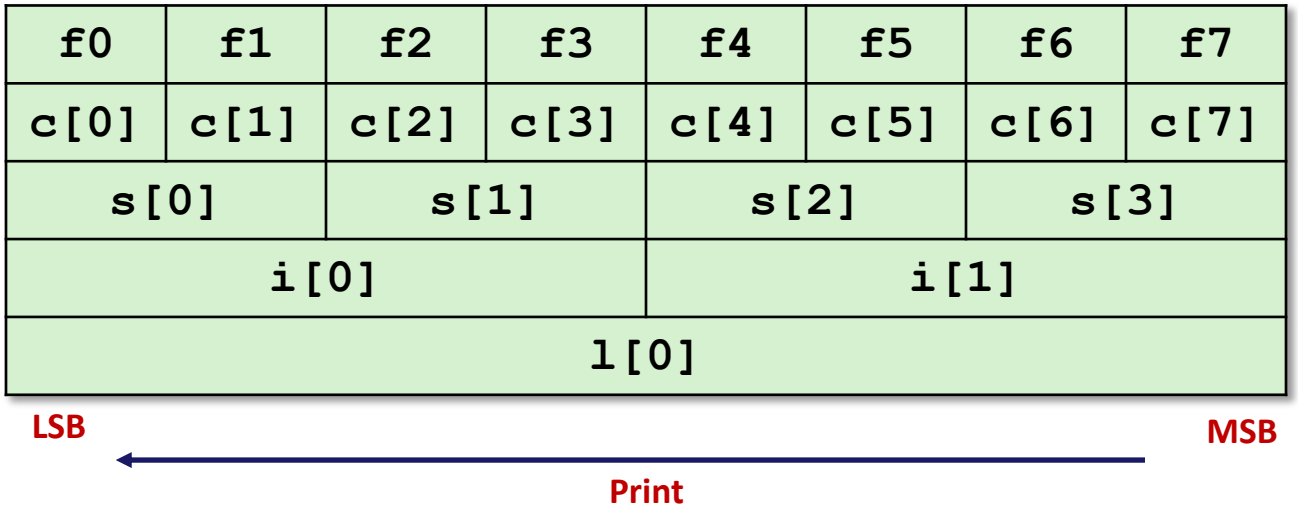


Output on Sun:

```
Characters 0-7 == [0xf0,0xf1,0xf2,0xf3,0xf4,0xf5,0xf6,0xf7]
Shorts     0-3 == [0xf0f1,0xf2f3,0xf4f5,0xf6f7]
Ints       0-1 == [0xf0f1f2f3,0xf4f5f6f7]
Long       0   == [0xf0f1f2f3]
```

Byte Ordering on x86-64

Little Endian



Output on x86-64:

```
Characters 0-7 == [0xf0,0xf1,0xf2,0xf3,0xf4,0xf5,0xf6,0xf7]
Shorts     0-3 == [0xf1f0,0xf3f2,0xf5f4,0xf7f6]
Ints       0-1 == [0xf3f2f1f0,0xf7f6f5f4]
Long       0   == [0xf7f6f5f4f3f2f1f0]
```

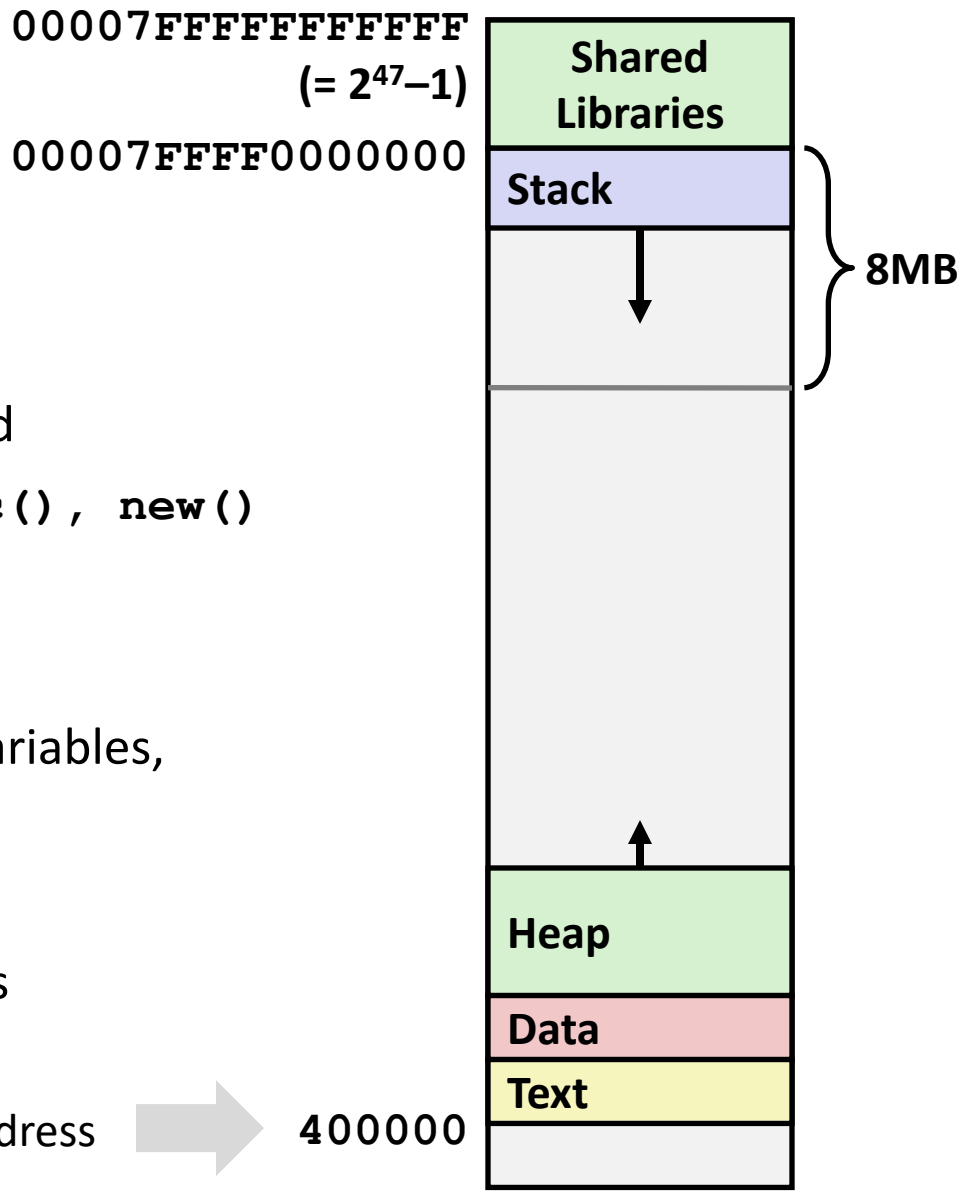
Today

- Unions
- **Memory Layout**
- Buffer Overflow
  - Vulnerability
  - Protection

x86-64 Linux Memory Layout

not drawn to scale

- **Stack**
  - Runtime stack (8MB limit)
  - e.g., local variables
- **Heap**
  - Dynamically allocated as needed
  - When call `malloc(), calloc(), new()`
- **Data**
  - Statically allocated data
  - e.g., global variables, `static` variables, string constants
- **Text / Shared Libraries**
  - Executable machine instructions
  - Read-only



not drawn to scale

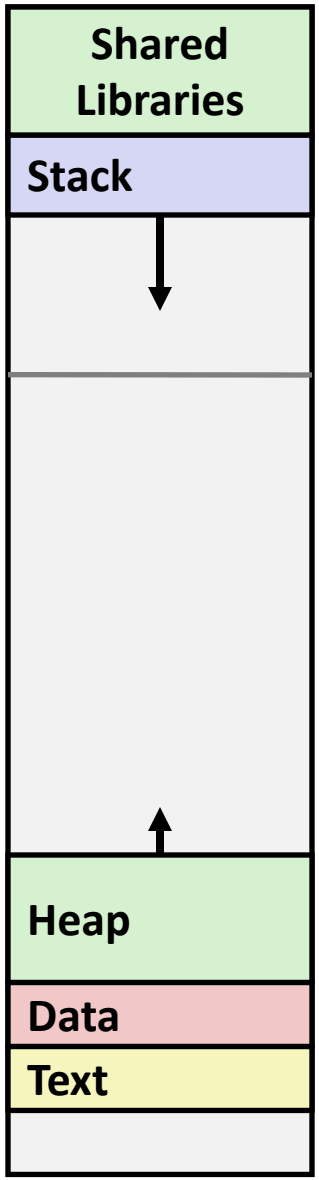
Memory Allocation Example

```
char big_array[1L<<24];  /* 16 MB */
char huge_array[1L<<31]; /*  2 GB */

int global = 0;

int useless() { return 0; }

int main ()
{
 void *phuge1, *psmall2, *phuge3, *psmall4;
    int local = 0;
    phuge1 = malloc(1L << 28);  /* 256 MB */
    psmall2 = malloc(1L << 8);  /* 256  B */
    phuge3 = malloc(1L << 32);  /*   4 GB */
    psmall4 = malloc(1L << 8);  /* 256  B */
 /* Some print statements ... */
```



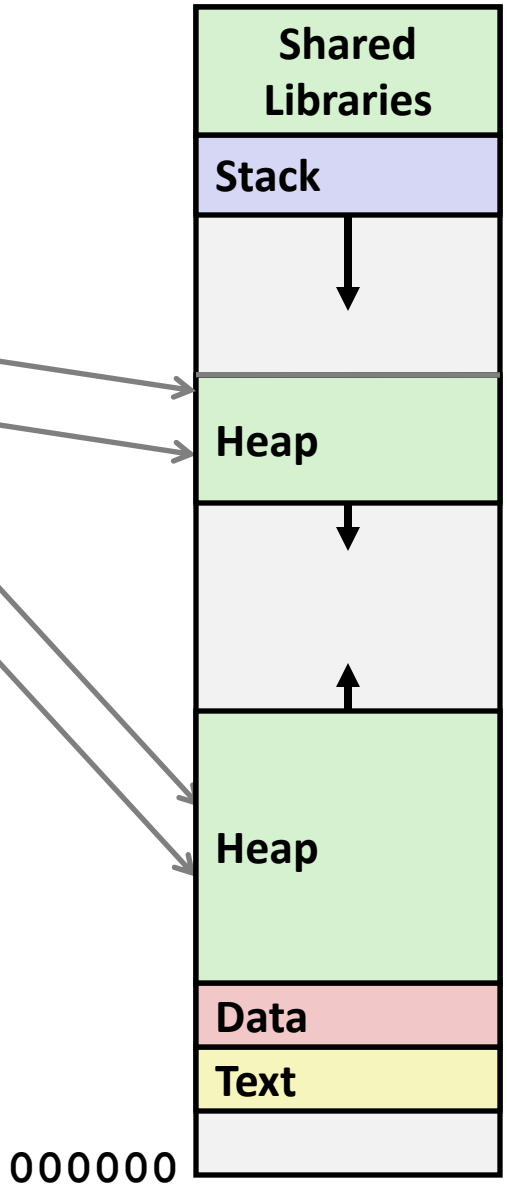
Where does everything go?

not drawn to scale

x86-64 Example Addresses

address range ~2^{47}

`local`	`0x00007ffee83bea7c`
`phuge1`	`0x00007f93bdc00000`
`phuge3`	`0x00007f92bdc00000`
`psmall4`	`0x00007f93cdd04ac0`
`psmall2`	`0x00007f93cdd04bc0`
`big_array`	`0x0000000080601060`
`huge_array`	`0x0000000000601060`
`main()`	`0x000000000040060c`
`useless()`	`0x0000000000400590`



(Exact values can vary)

Today

- Unions
- Memory Layout
- **Buffer Overflow**
  - Vulnerability
  - Protection

Recall: Memory Referencing Bug Example

```
typedef struct {
  int a[2];
  double d;
} struct_t;

double fun(int i) {
  volatile struct_t s;
  s.d = 3.14;
  s.a[i] = 1073741824; /* Possibly out of bounds */
  return s.d;
}
```

```
fun(0)   ->    3.14
fun(1)   ->    3.14
fun(2)   ->    3.1399998664856
fun(3)   ->    2.00000061035156
fun(4)   ->    3.14
fun(6)   ->    Segmentation fault
```

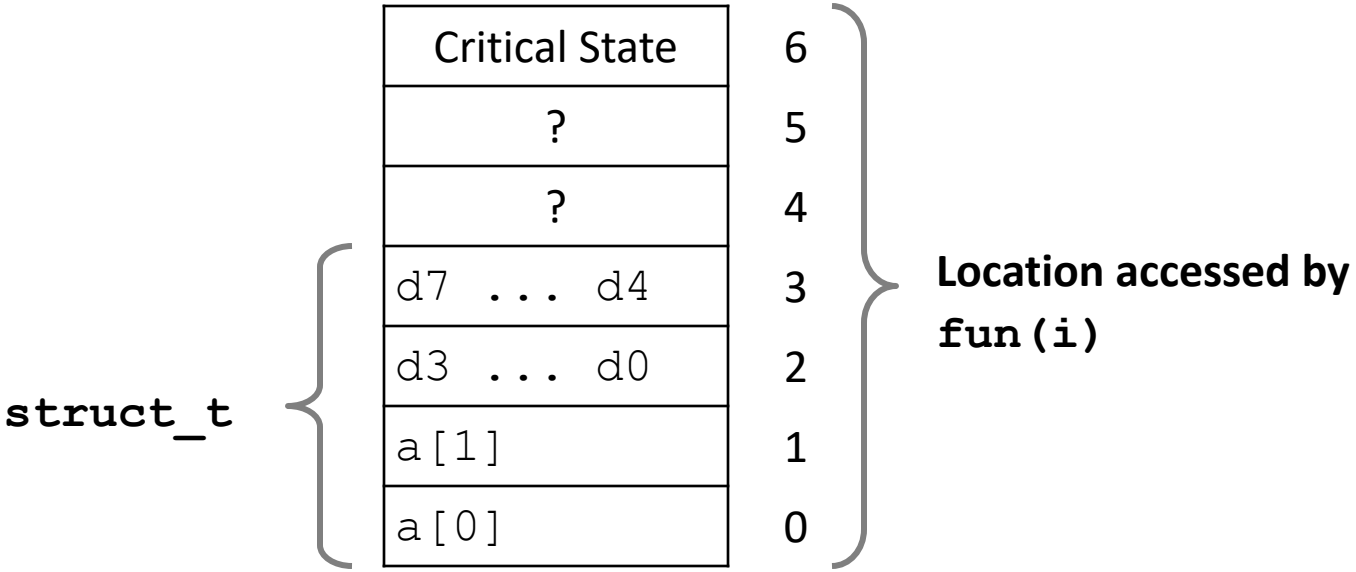
- Result is system specific

Memory Referencing Bug Example

```
typedef struct {
  int a[2];
  double d;
} struct_t;
```

```
fun(0)   ->   3.14
fun(1)   ->   3.14
fun(2)   ->   3.1399998664856
fun(3)   ->   2.0000061035156
fun(4)   ->   3.14
fun(6)   ->   Segmentation fault
```

Explanation:



Such problems are a BIG deal

- **Generally called a "buffer overflow"**
  - when exceeding the memory size allocated for an array
- **Why a big deal?**
  - It's the #1 technical cause of security vulnerabilities
    - #1 overall cause is social engineering / user ignorance
- **Most common form**
  - Unchecked lengths on string inputs
  - Particularly for bounded character arrays on the stack
    - sometimes referred to as stack smashing

String Library Code

- **Implementation of Unix function `gets()`**

```
/* Get string from stdin */
char *gets(char *dest)
{
    int c = getchar();
    char *p = dest;
    while (c != EOF && c != '\n') {
        *p++ = c;
        c = getchar();
    }
    *p = '\0';
    return dest;
}
```

  - No way to specify limit on number of characters to read

- **Similar problems with other library functions**
  - **`strcpy`, `strcat`**: Copy strings of arbitrary length
  - **`scanf`, `fscanf`, `sscanf`,** when given **`%s`** conversion specification

Vulnerable Buffer Code

```
/* Echo Line */
void echo()
{
    char buf[4];  /* Way too small! */
    gets(buf);
    puts(buf);
}
```

```
void call_echo() {
    echo();
}
```

```
unix>./bufdemo-nsp
Type a string:0123456789012345678901234
0123456789012345678901234
```

```
unix>./bufdemo-nsp
Type a string:01234567890123456789012345
Segmentation Fault
```

Buffer Overflow Disassembly

echo:

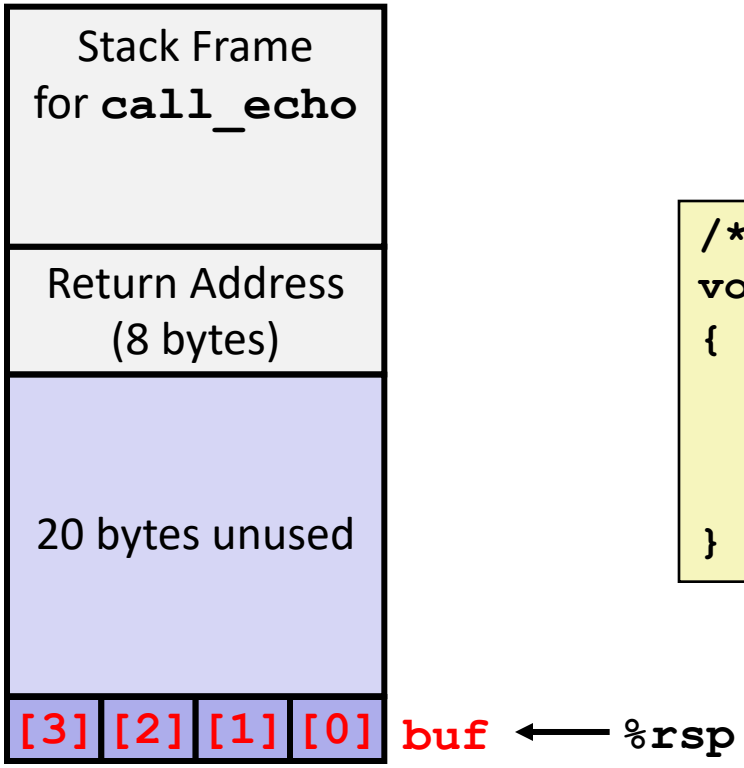
```
0000000004006cf <echo>:
 4006cf:  48 83 ec 18           sub    $0x18,%rsp
 4006d3:  48 89 e7              mov    %rsp,%rdi
 4006d6:  e8 a5 ff ff ff        callq  400680 <gets>
 4006db:  48 89 e7              mov    %rsp,%rdi
 4006de:  e8 3d fe ff ff        callq  400520 <puts@plt>
 4006e3:  48 83 c4 18           add    $0x18,%rsp
 4006e7:  c3                    retq
```

call_echo:

```
4006e8:   48 83 ec 08          sub    $0x8,%rsp
 4006ec:  b8 00 00 00 00        mov    $0x0,%eax
 4006f1:  e8 d9 ff ff ff        callq  4006cf <echo>
 4006f6:  48 83 c4 08           add    $0x8,%rsp
 4006fa:  c3                    retq
```

Buffer Overflow Stack Example

Before call to gets

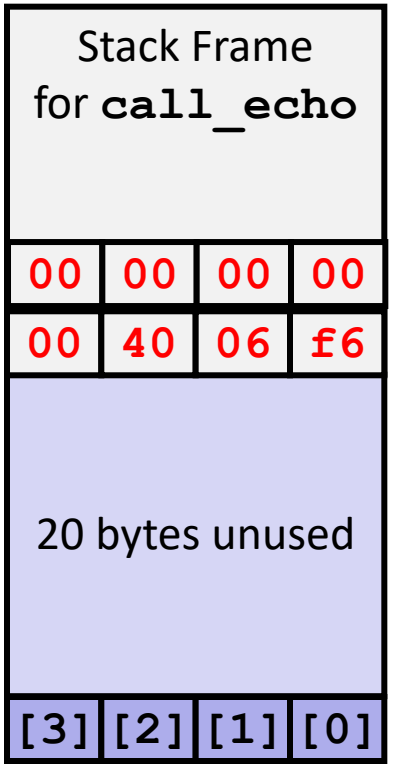



```
/* Echo Line */
void echo()
{
    char buf[4];  /* Way too small! */
    gets(buf);
    puts(buf);
}
```

```
echo:
   subq   $24, %rsp
   movq   %rsp, %rdi
   call   gets
   . . .
```

Buffer Overflow Stack Example

Before call to gets




```
void echo()
{
    char buf[4];
    gets(buf);
    . . .
}
```

```
echo:
   subq   $24, %rsp
   movq   %rsp, %rdi
   call   gets
   . . .
```

call_echo:

```
   . . .
   4006f1:  callq  4006cf <echo>
   4006f6:  add    $0x8,%rsp
   . . .
```

Buffer Overflow Stack Example #1

After call to gets

Stack Frame for `call_echo`

00	00	00	00
00	40	06	f6
00	32	31	30
39	38	37	36
35	34	33	32
31	30	39	38
37	36	35	34
33	32	31	30

buf ← %rsp

```
void echo()
{
    char buf[4];
    gets(buf);
    . . .
}
```

```
echo:
   subq   $24, %rsp
   movq   %rsp, %rdi
   call   gets
   . . .
```

call_echo:

```
   . . .
   4006f1:  callq  4006cf <echo>
   4006f6:  add    $0x8,%rsp
   . . .
```

```
unix>./bufdemo-nsp
Type a string:012345678901234567890123
012345678901234567890123
```

`012345678901234567890123\0`

Overflowed buffer, but did not corrupt state

Buffer Overflow Stack Example #2

After call to gets

Stack Frame for `call_echo`

00	00	00	00
00	40	00	34
33	32	31	30
39	38	37	36
35	34	33	32
31	30	39	38
37	36	35	34
33	32	31	30

buf ← %rsp

```
void echo()
{
    char buf[4];
    gets(buf);
    . . .
}
```

```
echo:
   subq   $24, %rsp
   movq   %rsp, %rdi
   call   gets
   . . .
```

call_echo:

```
   . . .
   4006f1:  callq  4006cf <echo>
   4006f6:  add    $0x8,%rsp
   . . .
```

```
unix>./bufdemo-nsp
Type a string:0123456789012345678901234
Segmentation Fault
```

```
0123456789012345678901234\0
```

Overflowed buffer and corrupted return pointer

Buffer Overflow Stack Example #3

After call to gets

Stack Frame for `call_echo`

00	00	00	00
00	40	06	00
33	32	31	30
39	38	37	36
35	34	33	32
31	30	39	38
37	36	35	34
33	32	31	30

buf ← %rsp

```
void echo()
{
    char buf[4];
    gets(buf);
    . . .
}
```

```
echo:
   subq   $24, %rsp
   movq   %rsp, %rdi
   call   gets
   . . .
```

call_echo:

```
   . . .
   4006f1:  callq  4006cf <echo>
   4006f6:  add    $0x8,%rsp
   . . .
```

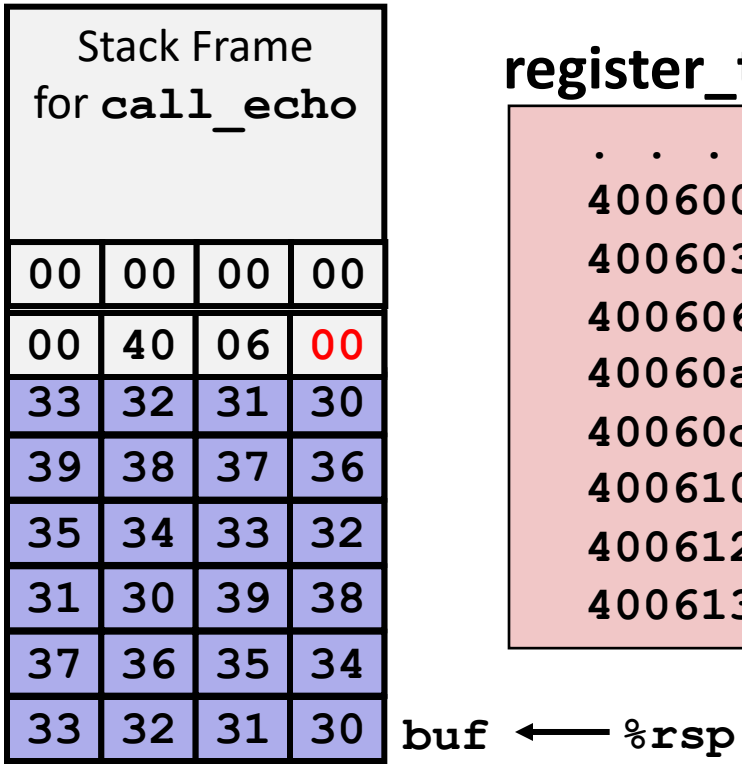
```
unix>./bufdemo-nsp
Type a string:0123456789012345678901234
0123456789012345678901234
```

```
0123456789012345678901234\0
```

Overflowed buffer, corrupted return pointer, but program seems to work!

Buffer Overflow Stack Example #3 Explained

After call to gets



register_tm_clones:

```
. . .
400600:  mov    %rsp,%rbp
400603:  mov    %rax,%rdx
400606:  shr    $0x3f,%rdx
40060a:  add    %rdx,%rax
40060d:  sar    %rax
400610:  jne    400614
400612:  pop    %rbp
400613:  retq
```

"Returns" to unrelated code
Lots of things happen, without modifying critical state
Eventually executes `retq` back to `main`

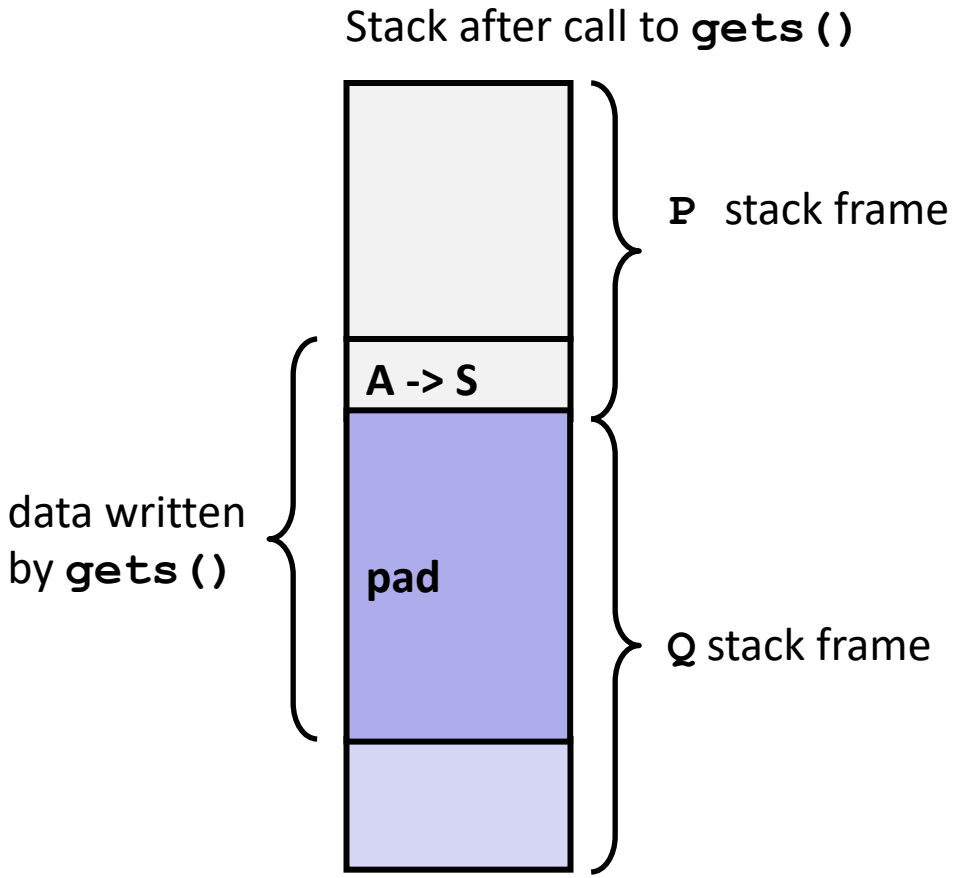
Code Injection Attacks

```
void P(){
  Q();
  ...
}
```

return address A

```
int Q() {
  char buf[64];
  gets(buf);
  ...
  return ...;
}
```

```
void S(){
  /* something
    unexpected */
  ...
}
```



- Overwrite return address A with address of some other code S
- When Q executes `ret`, will jump to exploit code

What to do about buffer overflow attacks

- Avoid overflow vulnerabilities
- Employ system-level protections
- Have compiler use “stack canaries”

1. Avoid Overflow Vulnerabilities in Code (!)

```
/* Echo Line */
void echo()
{
    char buf[4];  /* Way too small! */
    fgets(buf, 4, stdin);
    puts(buf);
}
```

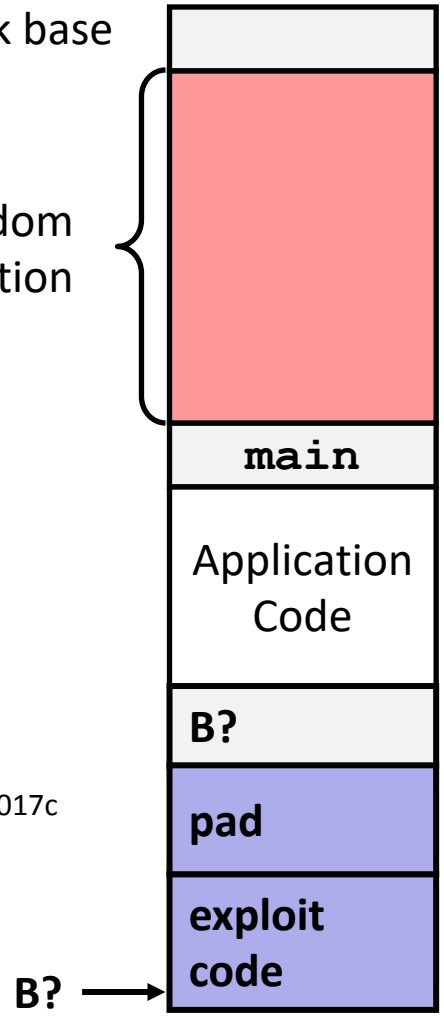
- **For example, use library routines that limit string lengths**
  - **fgets** instead of **gets**
  - **strncpy** instead of **strcpy**
  - Don't use **scanf** with **%s** conversion specification
    - Use **fgets** to read the string
    - Or use **%ns** where **n** is a suitable integer

2. System-Level Protections can help

- **Randomized stack offsets**
  - At start of program, allocate random amount of space on stack
  - Shifts stack addresses for entire program
  - Makes it difficult for hacker to predict beginning of inserted code
  - E.g.: 5 executions of memory allocation code

local 0x7ffe4d3be87c 0x7fff75a4f9fc 0x7ffeadb7c80c 0x7ffeaea2fdac 0x7ffcd452017c

    - Stack repositioned each time program executes



Summary of Compound Types in C

- **Arrays**
  - Contiguous allocation of memory
  - Aligned to satisfy every element's alignment requirement
  - Pointer to first element
  - No bounds checking
- **Structures**
  - Allocate bytes in order declared
  - Pad in middle and at end to satisfy alignment
- **Unions**
  - Overlay declarations
  - Way to circumvent type system